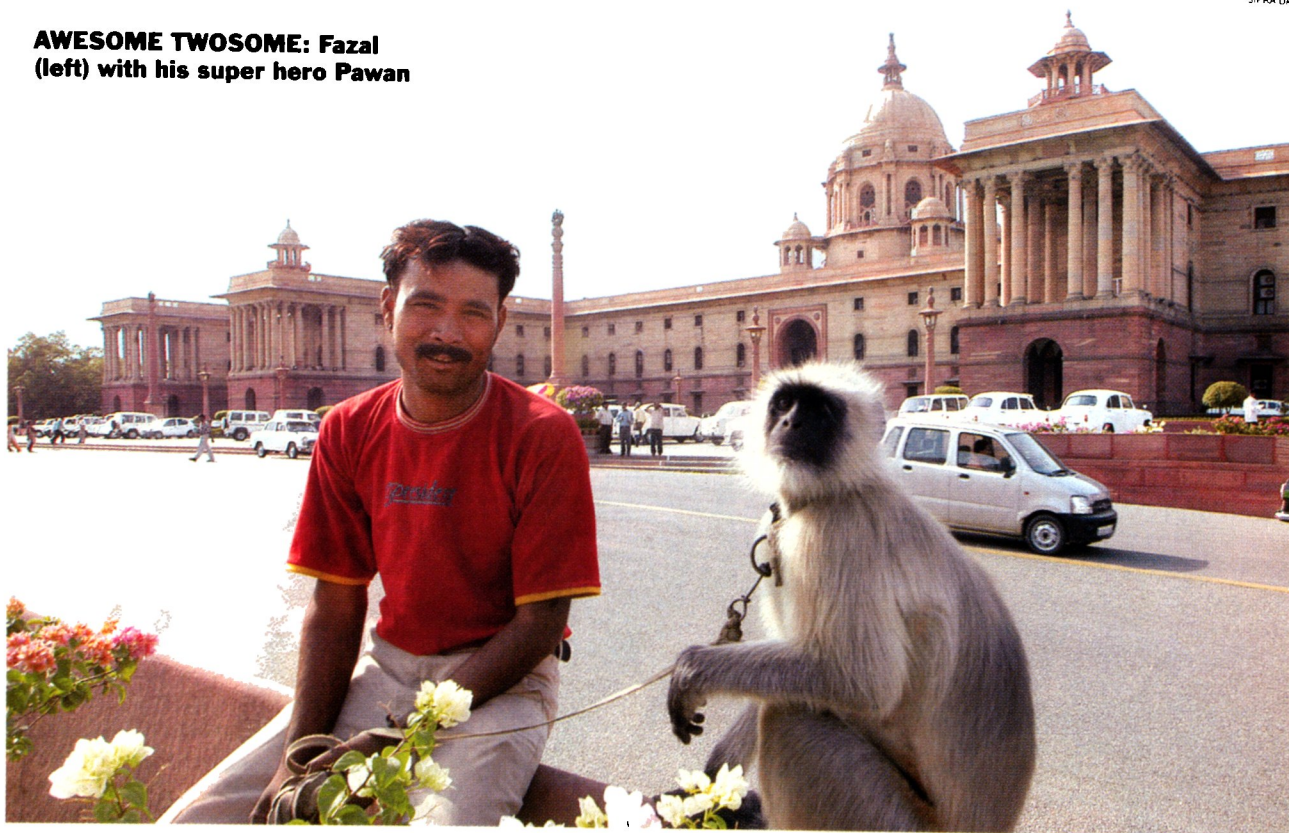


AWESOME TWOSOME: Fazal (left) with his super hero Pawan



Monkey Business

India's most important office complex has a unique security force to keep monkey menace at bay

■ By Sandeep Unnithan

Munching gram during office hours and lounging around South Block, Pawan could be just another job-shirking government employee. But, he is no ordinary contract worker. In fact, Pawan is one of the nearly half dozen langurs, tasked with keeping the South Block monkey-free. Sitting on a ledge 10-feet off the ground, with a gaze framed by huge eyebrows shooting out of a charcoal black face, the sinewy, three-feet tall simian keeps a wary look-out for his smaller rhesus macaque cousins. Pawan is the bully on the block; the smaller monkeys scamper away at a swish of his long tail.

Over the years, India's most important office complex, which houses the ministries of defence, foreign affairs and the Prime Minister's Office (PMO), has experimented with several solutions, including nets and monkey trappers to keep the animals away. But these experiments failed to deter the troops of monkeys from swinging through the corridors of power.

Hundreds of simian pests have been known to disturb meetings, ransack offices and snatch food from the terrified employees. So recently, the Government called in the



langur patrol—whom these smaller rhesus monkeys are afraid of. So, while Pawan's consort Rani sits on duty outside Defence Minister A.K. Antony's office, cradling her new-born infant, Kundan and Karan Singh guard the PMO and the rear gates of the South Block. They follow a 12-hour shift, which begins at 7 a.m. And, since then there has been no trace of intruders.

Langurs have also become life savers for Khan and his family, who were a group of monkey performers three years ago. They lost their livelihood when the Government banned the occupation. Later, he moved into this line of work, when a smart monkey-handler figured, it took a monkey to chase one. It takes around four months to train a langur and the hard work pays well too. A trained langur can fetch his owner a wholesome Rs 5,000 per month. Fazal's calling card is an elaborate: "call us to solve your monkey worries", which also has a cliff-hanger picture of Pawan chasing a hapless monkey, high above the South Block.

But this solution works only during the office hours. After a hard day's work, when Fazal kick starts his bike and Pawan hops on the pillion for a ride back home, the rhesus troops are already creeping in, to re-occupy their former territory. ■